

Right to Protest and Excessive Policing



For Prelims: Right to protest , Freedom of speech , National Human Rights Commission , UN Convention Against Torture , Article 21

For Mains: Right to Protest and Reasonable Restrictions under Article 19, Police Reforms and Democratic Policing in India, Public Order vs Civil Liberties

Source: TH

Why in News?

Violent clashes between protesters and police during the **youth-led 'Chalo Sansad' march** in New Delhi in July 2026 have reignited debate over the **constitutional limits of policing public protests** and the State's power to restrict civil and digital liberties.

- The demonstrations witnessed Metro station closures and **internet restrictions** , along with allegations of the use of tear gas, **pellet guns, shock batons**, and lathi charges by security forces, prompting legal scrutiny before the Delhi High Court.

Summary

- The **'Chalo Sansad' protests (July 2026)** reignited debate over balancing the **constitutional right to protest** with the State's responsibility to maintain **public order** , highlighting issues of excessive policing, internet shutdowns, and civil liberties.
- The article examines the **constitutional, statutory, and judicial framework** governing protests and police powers while emphasizing the need for **accountable, rights-based, and democratic policing** through institutional reforms.

What is the Constitutional Basis for the Right to Protest?

- Right to Protest:** The Indian Constitution guarantees the **right to protest** , though the word

"protest" is not explicitly mentioned. It is implicitly derived from a combination of fundamental rights under **Part III** :

- **Article 19(1)(a):** Guarantees the freedom of speech and expression.
- **Article 19(1)(b):** Grants the right to assemble peacefully and without arms.
- **Article 19(1)(c):** Ensures the right to form associations or unions.
- **Article 21:** Protects the right to life and liberty, which encompasses the right to live with dignity and voice grievances against the State.
- These rights are essential in a democracy to hold the **executive accountable, ventilate public grievances, and foster informed public discourse.**
- **Limitations on the Right to Protest: The right to protest is not absolute.** Under the Constitution, the State can impose "**reasonable restrictions**" on these fundamental freedoms.
 - **Under Article 19(2):** **Restrictions on freedom of speech** can be imposed in the interests of the sovereignty and integrity of India, the security of the State, friendly relations with foreign States, **public order** , decency or morality, or in relation to contempt of court, defamation, or incitement to an offence.
 - **Under Article 19(3):** Restrictions on the freedom of assembly can be imposed in the interests of the **sovereignty and integrity of India** or **public order** .
- **Statutory Framework:** Executive powers to regulate protests stem from statutory laws:
 - **Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023** empowers Executive Magistrates to issue prohibitory orders in urgent situations to prevent public disturbance.
 - **Local Police** statutes like the **Delhi Police Act, 1978** authorise law enforcement to regulate assembly routes, timings, and conditions.
- **Definition of Unlawful Assembly:** Under the **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023** , a gathering of five or more individuals becomes an "unlawful assembly" only if its common object involves using criminal force, resisting the law, committing an offence, or compelling others by threat.
 - A lawful assembly can turn unlawful if its conduct changes during the event.

What Standards and Laws Govern Police Action and Crowd Control?

- **Democratic Policing Framework:** The **National Human Rights Commission's (NHRC) Manual on Human Rights for Police Officers** emphasizes that police serve as protectors of citizen rights and the rule of law. It highlights that excessive force erodes public trust and escalates civil unrest.
- **International Principles:** Police action must align with the **UN Basic Principles on the Use of Force and Firearms (1990)** , which mandate that force must always be lawful, strictly necessary, and proportionate.
- **Principle of Minimum Force:** Under the BNSS, 2023 and the **Code of Conduct for the Police in India** , officers must prioritize warnings, advice, and persuasion. When force becomes unavoidable, only the "irreducible minimum force" required may be applied.
- **Identification and Accountability:** The BNSS, 2023 and the Supreme Court's landmark judgment in **D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal (1997)** requires police personnel **making arrests to wear clear, accurate, and visible name tags.**
 - However, current statutes lack an explicit parallel requirement for personnel engaged purely in crowd control or assembly dispersal—creating accountability gaps when officers conceal their faces or remove name tags.

Supreme Court Judgments on Protests and Police Excess

- **Ram Manohar Lohia v. State of Bihar (1965):** In **Ram Manohar Lohia v. State of Bihar (1965)** , the Supreme Court distinguished between "**law and order**" and "**public order**." It held that **law and order** concerns disturbances affecting **individuals or a limited group** , whereas **public order** refers to disturbances that affect the **community or society at large** .
 - Therefore, **the State may restrict protests only when they pose a genuine threat to public order, not merely because they cause routine law and order issues.**
- **Himat Lal K. Shah v. Commissioner of Police (1973):** The Supreme Court held that while the State may regulate assemblies on public streets, it cannot impose arbitrary restrictions that extinguish the right to protest.
- **In Re: Ramlila Maidan Incident (2012):** The Court held that citizens have a constitutional right to peaceful protest, and force must be used only as a last resort with maximum restraint.
- **Anita Thakur v. State of Jammu & Kashmir (2016):** The Court ruled that the use of excessive police force on demonstrators violates fundamental rights and awarded monetary compensation to injured protesters.
- **Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan v. Union of India (2018):** Reaffirmed that while police can regulate demonstrations to maintain public order, they cannot extinguish the **right to assemble altogether**.
- **Amit Sahni v. Commissioner of Police (2020):** The Court ruled that while dissent is a constitutional right, protests cannot result in the indefinite occupation of public spaces or block traffic corridors.

What are the Concerns Regarding Excessive Policing?

- **Political Interference:** Political influence over transfers, postings, and investigations undermines police independence and impartiality.
- **Outdated Training:** Police training gives inadequate emphasis to **human rights, de-escalation techniques, forensic investigation, and community policing** , increasing the risk of excessive force.
 - Although India became a signatory to the **UN Convention Against Torture (UNCAT)** in 1997, it has yet to ratify the treaty or pass specific domestic legislation criminalizing torture.
- **Manpower Shortages and Occupational Stress:** As of **January 2024** , India has **155 police personnel per lakh population** , well below the **UN-recommended norm of 222** , with nearly **21% vacancies** .
 - Long working hours and excessive workload have resulted in **83.8% of personnel reporting high stress (SPIR 2025)** , contributing to **burnout, impaired judgement, and an increased reliance on coercive policing**.
- **Disproportionate Use of Force:** The use of **tear gas, lathi charges, preventive detention, and mass arrests** against peaceful demonstrators often violates the **Doctrine of Proportionality** , which requires State action to be **lawful, necessary, and the least restrictive** .
 - It also departs from the **UN Basic Principles on the Use of Force and Firearms** , which mandate **minimum necessary force** .
- **Lack of Transparency and Accountability:** Allegations of **unidentified individuals participating**

- **in crowd-control operations** , police officers **without visible name badges** , and masked personnel undermine accountability.
- This is inconsistent with the principles laid down in ***D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal (1997)*** , which emphasised identifiable police personnel and transparent law enforcement.
- **Violation of Gender-Sensitive Safeguards:** Reports of **manhandling women protesters** , arbitrary detention, or inadequate deployment of **women police personnel** undermine constitutional guarantees of **dignity under Article 21** and statutory safeguards requiring women to be handled by women police, except in exceptional circumstances.
- **Digital Restrictions Beyond Constitutional Limits:** Blanket **internet shutdowns, signal jammers, and communication blackouts** during protests can disproportionately restrict **Articles 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(g)** .
 - In ***Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India (2020)*** , the Supreme Court held that such restrictions must satisfy the tests of **legality, necessity, proportionality, publication, and periodic review** .
- **Weak Civilian Oversight:** The poor implementation of the **Prakash Singh (2006)** directives, particularly the ineffective functioning of **Police Complaints Authorities (PCAs)** and **State Security Commissions (SSCs)** , weakens independent scrutiny of police misconduct and perpetuates institutional impunity.
 - Under-reporting of police misconduct and the absence of **independent oversight mechanisms** foster a culture of impunity.
- **Colonial Police Structure:** The **Police Act, 1861** created a force primarily accountable to the executive rather than the public.
 - Despite the **Model Police Act, 2006** , most States continue with the colonial framework, weakening democratic policing.

Way Forward

- **Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs):** Police forces must be extensively trained in the application of the new BNSS/BNS provisions, specifically emphasizing non-lethal crowd control tactics and negotiation.
- **Implement the Prakash Singh Directives:** To ensure impartial investigations into police brutality, state governments must urgently comply with the Supreme Court's directive in *Prakash Singh v. Union of India* (2006) by operationalizing truly independent, legally empowered State and District Police Complaints Authorities (PCAs).
- **Separation of Investigation and Law & Order:** As recommended by the **Second Administrative Reforms Commission (2nd ARC)** and the **Malimath Committee** , separating investigation from law and order duties would improve the quality of investigations through **scientific forensics** and reduce reliance on **coerced confessions** .
- **Modernization and Capacity Building:** The **Modernization of Police Forces (MPF)** scheme must be expedited to fill the 21% manpower gap, improve the officer-to-citizen ratio, and introduce technology-driven policing (e.g., mandatory body-worn cameras and CCTV in all police stations).
 - Transition from regime policing to **SMART** policing by making the force **S** trict and Sensitive, **M** odern and Mobile, **A** lert and Accountable, **R** eliable and Responsive, **T** ech-savvy and Trained.

Conclusion

The **right to protest** is a cornerstone of India's constitutional democracy, while **public order**

remains a legitimate State responsibility. Any restriction on protests must uphold the **Rule of Law** , **Constitutional Morality** , and the **Doctrine of Proportionality** , ensuring that state action is **lawful, necessary, proportionate, transparent, and subject to judicial review** . The **Chalo Sansad** episode underscores the need to balance **democratic dissent with public security** in accordance with the Constitution.

Drishti Mains Question:

"The right to protest is fundamental but not absolute." Examine the constitutional and statutory framework governing public protests in India.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What constitutional provisions form the basis of the Right to Protest in India?

The right to protest is derived from **Articles 19(1)(a), 19(1)(b), 19(1)(c), and Article 21** , subject to reasonable restrictions under **Articles 19(2) and 19(3)** .

2. What is the significance of the Prakash Singh (2006) judgment?

The Supreme Court directed the establishment of **State Security Commissions, Police Complaints Authorities, Police Establishment Boards** , and fixed tenure for senior police officers to ensure police autonomy and accountability.

3. What principles govern police use of force during protests?

Police action must follow the principles of **legality, necessity, proportionality, and minimum force** , as laid down in the **BNSS** , **NHRC guidelines** , and the **UN Basic Principles on the Use of Force and Firearms (1990)** .

4. What did the Supreme Court hold in Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India (2020)?

The Court held that **internet shutdowns must satisfy the tests of legality, necessity, proportionality, publication, and periodic review** , making blanket restrictions constitutionally impermissible.

5. Why is police reform essential for democratic policing in India?

Police reforms are needed to **reduce political interference, strengthen accountability, improve professionalism, modernize policing, and protect fundamental rights while maintaining public order** .

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. Right of movement and residence throughout the territory of India are freely available to the Indian citizens, but these rights are not absolute. Comment. **(2022)**

Q. What do you understand by the concept of “freedom of speech and expression”? Does it cover hate speech also? Why do the films in India stand on a slightly different plane from other forms of expression? Discuss. **(2014)**

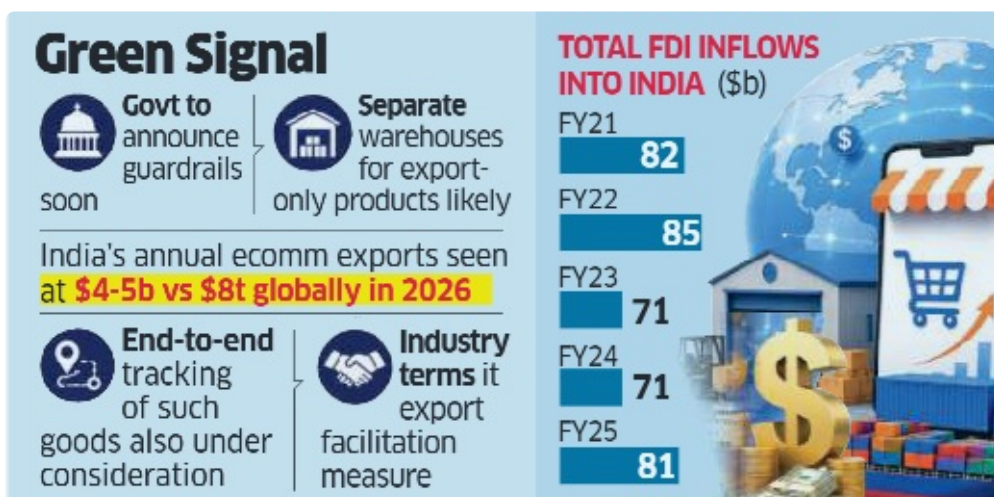
India Allows FDI in Inventory-Based E-Commerce Model for Exports



Source: ET

Why in News?

The government has revised the **Foreign Direct Investment policy** to permit foreign-funded e-commerce entities to maintain inventories exclusively for exporting goods manufactured or produced in India.



What are the Key Facts About Revised Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) Policy?

- **About:** Foreign-owned e-commerce companies can **now own and manage inventory in India**, provided the goods are domestically produced and sold only in overseas markets. The **Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade** has created an **export-specific exception** to the restrictions on inventory-based e-commerce.
 - **However, foreign-funded inventory-based e-commerce remains prohibited for domestic retail sales**, preserving safeguards for small traders and the ban on FDI in multi-brand retail.
- **Objective :** The policy aims to improve **Indian sellers' access to global markets**, promote exports and reduce the compliance burden on MSMEs. The measure could **help Tier-2 and Tier-3 manufacturers, artisans and small businesses** export products such as handicrafts, garments, books, art, gems and jewellery.
- **Beneficiaries:** Global platforms such as Amazon and Walmart-owned Flipkart can source products from Indian manufacturers, manage inventories and handle export-related paperwork, testing, labelling and traceability requirements.
- **Implementation:** The decision will take effect after the relevant notification under the **Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999**.

- **Existing Policy:** India earlier permitted **100% FDI under the automatic route only in marketplace-based e-commerce and B2B e-commerce**, while prohibiting FDI in inventory-based models.
- **Concerns:** Critics argue that **separating export and domestic inventories may be difficult to monitor** and could eventually create pressure to permit foreign-funded inventory-based e-commerce in the domestic market.

FDI policy evolution for ecom

2000: Foreign direct investments allowed in business-to-business ecommerce under automatic route

2016: FDI permitted in marketplace model under automatic route

■ FDI prohibited in inventory-based B2C ecommerce

2018: Marketplace entities barred from exercising ownership or

control over inventory

■ Curbs tightened on vendor purchases, exclusive arrangements

2026: FDI allowed in inventory-based ecom entities for exclusively exporting domestically manufactured goods

■ Ban on FDI in inventory-based domestic B2C ecom unchanged

Sources: PIB, Lok Sabha, DCA

Significance

- **Export Promotion:** Provides Indian sellers with an additional e-commerce channel to reach global consumers and expand merchandise exports.
- **Support for SMEs:** Benefits small and medium enterprises in sectors such as apparel, jewellery, handicrafts, home products and organic wellness by easing access to international markets.
- **Opportunities for Regional Manufacturers:** Enables manufacturers in tier-2 and tier-3 cities to widen their overseas customer base and participate more actively in global trade.
- **Long-Term Economic Impact:** Supports India's manufacturing and export-growth objectives, including the target of achieving \$80 billion in cumulative e-commerce exports by 2030.

Difference Between Major E-Commerce Models

Feature	Inventory-Based Model	Marketplace Model
Ownership of Goods	Owned by e-commerce entity	Owned by sellers
Role of Platform	An e-commerce entity owns the inventory and sells goods directly to consumers.	The platform acts as a facilitator between buyers and sellers.
FDI Status in India	Allowed only for exports under new policy	Up to 100% FDI is permitted under the automatic route
Domestic Retail	Foreign-funded inventory-based B2C e-commerce remains prohibited for domestic sales.	Foreign-funded platforms may facilitate domestic sales under marketplace rules but cannot own or control sellers' inventory
Export Potential	Direct export facilitation	Seller-driven exports

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is the recent change in India's FDI policy related to e-commerce?

Ans: The Government has allowed **Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in the inventory-based e-commerce model exclusively for exports** of domestically manufactured or produced goods.

Q2. Which organisation introduced the FDI policy change?

Ans: The policy change was introduced by the **Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT)** under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

Q3. Is FDI allowed in inventory-based e-commerce for domestic consumers?

Ans: No. FDI in inventory-based e-commerce for **domestic retail sales remains prohibited**. The relaxation applies only to exports.

Q4. What is an inventory-based e-commerce model?

Ans: In an inventory-based e-commerce model, the e-commerce entity **owns and controls the inventory** of goods and sells them directly to consumers or buyers.

Q5. How is the inventory-based model different from the marketplace model?

Ans:

- **Inventory-Based Model:** The e-commerce entity purchases, stores and sells goods directly.
- **Marketplace Model:** The platform only connects buyers and sellers and does not own inventory.

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▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/-vcuyORaTLY>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following: (2021)

1. Foreign currency convertible bonds
2. Foreign institutional investment with certain conditions
3. Global depository receipts
4. Non-resident external deposits

Which of the above can be included in Foreign Direct Investments?

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 4
- (d) 1 and 4

Ans: (a)

Q. With reference to Foreign Direct Investment in India, which one of the following is considered its major characteristic? (2020)

- (a) It is the investment through capital instruments essentially in a listed company.
- (b) It is a largely non-debt creating capital flow.
- (c) It is the investment which involves debt-servicing.
- (d) It is the investment made by foreign institutional investors in Government securities.

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Justify the need for FDI for the development of the Indian economy. Why is there a gap between MOUs signed and actual FDIs? Suggest remedial steps to be taken for increasing actual FDIs in India. (2016)

Sarnath: India's 45th UNESCO World Heritage Site



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath** in **Uttar Pradesh** has been **inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List** during the **48th Session of the World Heritage Committee** held in **Busan, Republic of Korea**.

- With the inscription of **Sarnath**, **India now has 45 UNESCO World Heritage Sites**, ranking **6th globally** and **2nd in the Asia-Pacific region** in terms of the number of World Heritage Sites.

What are the Key Facts About the Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath?

- **Historical and Spiritual Significance of Sarnath:** Sarnath is universally recognized in Buddhist tradition as the sacred geography where **Gautama Buddha delivered his first sermon in the 6th century BCE** after attaining enlightenment in Bodhgaya.
 - This monumental event is known as the **“Turning of the Wheel of the Law” (Dharmachakra Pravartana)**.
- **Birthplace of the Sangha:** It was at Sarnath that the Buddha met his first disciples, marking the formal inception of the **Buddhist monastic order (the Sangha)** and the establishment of the **Noble Eightfold Path**.
- **One of the Four Principal Pilgrimage Sites:** The Buddha himself indicated Sarnath as one of the four key sites of **Buddhist pilgrimage (alongside Lumbini, Bodhgaya, and Kushinagar)**.
 - With this inscription, three of these four primary sites - **Lumbini (Nepal), Mahabodhi Temple at Bodhgaya (India), and now Sarnath (India)** are protected as UNESCO World Heritage Properties.
 - They join several other important Buddhist World Heritage Sites, including **Sanchi, Nalanda, and Ajanta (India); Anuradhapura (Sri Lanka); Paharpur (Bangladesh); and Taxila and Takht-i-Bahi (Pakistan)**.
- **Historical Nomenclature:** In ancient texts, Sarnath is referred to by various names, including *Rishipatana*, *Ishipatana*, and *Mrigadava* (Deer Park).
- **National Emblems Found:** Excavations here yielded the famous **Mauryan Lion Capital** (which became the **National Emblem of India**) and the **Dharmachakra Pravartana Buddha statue** from the Classic Gupta Art period.
 - These are housed in India's earliest site museum, established at Sarnath in 1904.

Sarnath as a UNESCO World Heritage Property

- **UNESCO Selection Criteria:** Sarnath was placed on **India's Tentative List in 1998**. The site was nominated and accepted under **Criterion (iii)** (recognizing its enduring spiritual significance as a pilgrimage destination) and **Criterion (vi)** (its direct and tangible association with the life of the Buddha, his teachings, and the concept of the *Triratna* (the Three Jewels: Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha)).
- **Site Components:** The **UNESCO-inscribed serial property** comprises **Chaukhandi Stupa** (lofty brick structure), believed to mark the site where **Gautama Buddha met his first five disciples** and the **Archaeological Remains of Sarnath** (including the **Dhamekh Stupa, Dharmarajika Stupa, Mulagandhakuti Vihara, and Ashokan Pillar**) in **Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh**.
 - **Dhamekh Stupa:** A massive cylindrical stupa marking the site where **Gautama Buddha delivered**

his First Sermon (Dharmachakra Pravartana) .

- **Dharmarajika Stupa:** One of the **earliest Buddhist stupas** , traditionally believed to have been **commissioned by Emperor Ashoka** to enshrine sacred relics of the Buddha.
- **Mulagandhakuti Vihara:** Believed to mark the location of the **Buddha's residence during his first rainy season retreat (Varshavasa)** at Sarnath.
- **Ashokan Pillar:** A sandstone pillar erected by **Emperor Ashoka** in the 3rd century BCE; its **Lion Capital** is the **National Emblem of India** .
- The site also preserves the remains of **ancient temples, monasteries (viharas), shrines, and other archaeological structures** , reflecting Sarnath's evolution as a major centre of **Buddhist learning, pilgrimage, and monastic life** over more than two millennia.

What is a UNESCO World Heritage Site?

- **About:** A World Heritage Site is a landmark or area given legal protection by an international convention administered by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO).
- **The 1972 Convention:** Sites are designated based on the ***Convention Concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage*** , adopted in 1972. Currently, there are 1,248 properties across 170 countries on the list.
 - The UNESCO World Heritage Committee maintains the list through the World Heritage Programme.
 - **India ratified the Convention in 1977** and served as a member of the UNESCO World Heritage Committee from 2021 to 2025 and **hosted the 46 th Session of the World Heritage Committee in New Delhi in July 2024.**
 - India has 69 sites on UNESCO's Tentative List, the mandatory prerequisite for future nomination to the World Heritage List.
 - Each State Party can nominate only one site per year for consideration by the World Heritage Committee for inscription.
 - The **Archaeological Survey of India (ASI)** is the **nodal agency** for all UNESCO World Heritage matters in India.
- **Categories:**
 - **Cultural:** Historic buildings, archaeological sites, and works of monumental sculpture.
 - **Natural:** Outstanding physical, biological, and geological formations.
 - **Mixed:** Sites exhibiting both outstanding natural and cultural values (e.g., Mount Olympus in Greece; Khangchendzonga National Park in India).
- **List of World Heritage in Danger:** A separate mechanism designed to inform the international community of conditions threatening the characteristics for which a property was inscribed (e.g., armed conflict, natural disasters, unchecked urbanization) to catalyze corrective action.
- **Emergency Nomination Procedure:** A special mechanism under the **1972 UNESCO World Heritage Convention** that allows the **fast-track inscription of a site on the World Heritage List when it faces immediate and serious threats requiring urgent international recognition and protection.**
- **Implication:** Being listed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site brings global recognition, legal protection under international treaties, and eligibility for conservation funding, but it can also lead to over-tourism and commercial pressure.

2026 UNESCO’s List of World Heritage in Danger

World Heritage Site	Country / Territory	Status / Major Threat(s)
Boma-Badingilo Migratory Landscape	South Sudan	Emergency Inscription ; threatened by infrastructure development, commercial poaching, wildlife trafficking, insecurity, and weak conservation capacity.
Mount Amel Castles	Lebanon	Emergency Inscription ; severely threatened by ongoing armed conflict causing extensive damage.
Sebastia	State of Palestine	Emergency Inscription ; threatened by conflict, the proposed "Samaria" National Park, development pressures, land-use changes, and erosion of archaeological remains.
Ancient City of Tauric Chersonese and its Chora	Ukraine (Crimea)	Added to the World Heritage in Danger List due to temporary occupation, unauthorised construction, and deterioration of the site's integrity.
Historic Inner City of Paramaribo	Suriname	Added to the World Heritage in Danger List due to incompatible modern construction affecting its historic urban landscape.
Tyre	Lebanon	Added to the World Heritage in Danger List due to ongoing hostilities threatening its conservation.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is a UNESCO World Heritage Site?

A UNESCO World Heritage Site is a **cultural, natural, or mixed property** recognized for its **Outstanding Universal Value (OUV)** under the **1972 World Heritage Convention** and protected as part of humanity's shared heritage.

2. Why was Sarnath inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List?

Sarnath was inscribed under **Criteria (iii) and (vi)** for its enduring role as a **major Buddhist pilgrimage centre** and its direct association with **Buddha's First Sermon, the Buddhist Sangha, and the Triratna (Three Jewels)**.

3. What is the Emergency Nomination Procedure under UNESCO?

It is a **fast-track mechanism** under the **1972 World Heritage Convention** that allows the inscription of sites facing **immediate and serious threats**, enabling urgent international recognition and conservation.

4. What is the List of World Heritage in Danger?

It is a UNESCO mechanism that identifies **World Heritage Sites threatened by armed conflict, natural disasters, unchecked development, or other risks**, helping mobilize international assistance and corrective measures.

5. What is the role of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) in World Heritage conservation?

The **ASI** is the **nodal agency** for UNESCO World Heritage matters in India and is responsible for the **nomination, conservation, protection, monitoring, and management** of World Heritage Sites.

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▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/3w4bGVpMxSA>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following properties included in the World Heritage List released by UNESCO: (2024)

1. Shantiniketan
2. Rani-ki-Vav
3. Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas
4. Mahabodhi Temple Complex at Bodhgaya

How many of the above properties were included in 2023?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) Only three
- (d) All four

Ans: (b)

Mains :

Q.1 Safeguarding the Indian Art Heritage is the need of the moment. Discuss. **(2018)**

Q.2 Indian Philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss. **(2020)**

Scientists Develop IoT-Based Health Tracker for Yaks



Source: TH

Indian Scientists have developed an **IoT** -based smart collar to monitor the health, stress levels, and movement of **high-altitude yaks, especially in remote Himalayan grazing areas** near the international border.

- **About:** The Indian yak (*Bos grunniens*), known as the “**ship of the Himalayas** ”, is a high-altitude bovine valued for its ability to survive extreme cold and difficult terrain. It is an essential livelihood resource for Himalayan communities.

- **Distribution:** India has about **58,000 yaks**, with nearly half found in **Ladakh** . Other major yak-rearing regions include **Arunachal Pradesh, Sikkim, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand**. Wild yaks are mainly restricted to the **Tibetan Plateau** .
- **Habitat:** Yaks inhabit high-altitude **alpine meadows, alpine steppes, and desert steppes, generally between 3,200 and 5,400 metres** . They prefer cold plateaus and may migrate seasonally in search of grass, moss, and lichens.
- **Physical Features:** Wild male yaks may weigh up to **1,000 kg, while females weigh around 300 kg** . They have long blackish-brown hair, curved horns, broad hooves, large lungs, a high red blood cell count, and high haemoglobin concentration, enabling them to survive in low-oxygen environments.
- **Behaviour and Food Habits:** Yaks are mainly daytime grazers and live in herds. **Females and young usually form larger groups**, while adult males often remain alone or in smaller groups. Their diet includes grasses, shrubs, forbs, mosses, lichens, and other low-growing plants.
- **Reproduction and Lifespan:** The mating season of wild yaks generally begins in September, and calves are usually born in June after a gestation period of about nine months. Females generally produce **one calf every two years**, and wild yaks may live for about 25 years.
- **Conservation Status (Wild Yak)(*Bos mutus*):**
 - **IUCN Red List:** Vulnerable
 - **CITES:** Appendix I
 - **Wildlife Protection Act, 1972:** Schedule I



Read more: [Digitising India's Agriculture](#)

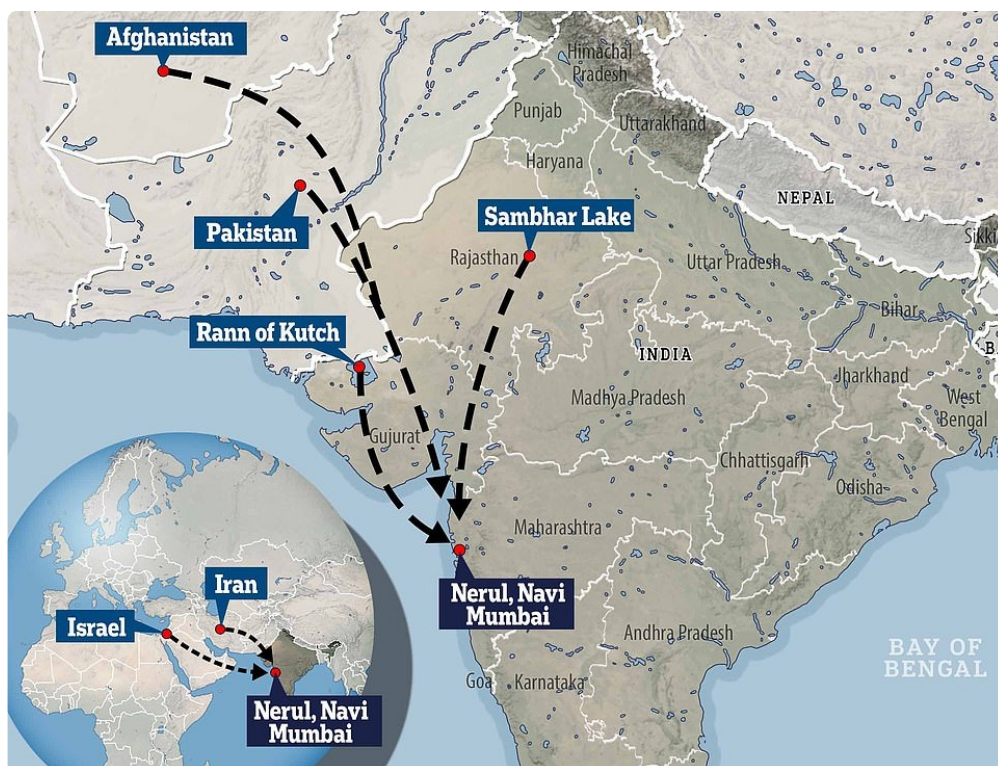
Maharashtra to Get India's 1st AI-Powered Bird Sanctuary



Source: TOI

Maharashtra has approved the development of a **₹45-crore Eco-Nature Park** at the **Thane Creek Flamingo Sanctuary** , featuring India's first **Artificial Intelligence (AI) -powered bird detection and monitoring centre** .

- **AI-Based Monitoring System:** The sanctuary will use **Artificial Intelligence-based cameras and monitoring systems** to identify bird species, track migration patterns and collect scientific data. The technology will analyse bird activity across a **1.5-kilometre stretch** of the park through automated image and sound recognition.
- **Thane Creek Flamingo Sanctuary:** Located between Mumbai and Navi Mumbai along Thane Creek, the sanctuary was declared a **wildlife sanctuary in 2015** and is India's first dedicated flamingo sanctuary.
 - It is an important coastal wetland ecosystem supporting thousands of flamingos and over **200 bird species** , including greater flamingos, lesser flamingos, herons, egrets, shorebirds and kingfishers.
- **Migratory Importance:** The sanctuary forms part of the **Central Asian Flyway** , an important migratory route connecting Europe, Central Asia and the Indian subcontinent.



Key Facts About Flamingos

- **About:** **Flamingos** are **tall water birds** known for their **long, S-shaped necks and stick-like legs**.
 - They are **highly social** and often **seen in large flocks** inhabiting **shallow, eutrophic water bodies** such as **saline lagoons, saltpans, and alkaline lakes**.
- **Species:** There are 6 species of flamingos found globally in **tropical and subtropical regions** , with **only 2 found in India (Greater & Lesser Flamingo)**.
 - **Other Species:**
 - **Chilean Flamingo** (*Phoenicopterus chilensis*)
 - **American/Caribbean Flamingo** (*Phoenicopterus ruber*)
 - **Andean Flamingo** (*Phoenicoparrus andinus*)
 - **James's or Puna Flamingo** (*Phoenicoparrus jamesi*)

- **Diet & Colouration:** Flamingos feed on **algae, molluscs, and crustaceans**. Their **plumage colour** , ranging from **white to pink** to orange, is determined by **carotenoid pigments** in their diet.
- **Habitat and Threats:** Flamingos depend on shallow wetlands, mudflats and coastal lagoons for feeding and breeding. Major threats include habitat degradation, pollution, coastal development, human disturbance and changes in water quality.

Read More: [Flamingos, Himalayan Ibex and Blue Sheep](#)